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PLAN TO MARCH TOWARDS ASSEMBLY TOMORROW

Jharkhand student protest: Round 2 of talks with govt fails to end deadlock

Protesters say demands will be taken to CM, no call to withdraw agitation yet

Shubham Tigga
Ranchi, August 8

THE SECOND round of talks between the Jharkhand government and student representatives protesting alleged irregularities in government recruitment examinations ended without a breakthrough on Saturday, prolonging a conflict that the state has so far struggled to resolve.

The students, however, said the government had listened to their demands and that they would wait for the issues to be taken up with Chief Minister Hemant Soren before deciding whether to withdraw their

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Stalled govt jobs, cases stuck in court, exam delays: What's behind the Ranchi fast, protest



Unne Habiba, 27



Rupesh Kumar Pal, 30



Savita Kumari, 28



Rahul Kranti, 40

Shubham Tigga
Ranchi, August 8

WHEN 40-YEAR-OLD Rahul Kranti walked into the protest site, he said he was carrying nearly a decade of frustration with Jharkhand's recruitment

system. On Friday, he was among the candidates on an indefinite hunger strike, saying repeated examinations, court battles and delayed recruitments had left him with little choice but to take to the streets. Like Kranti, those on the

stage symbolise the grievances that have simmered among the state's job aspirants over decades. From a woman attending her first-ever protest to a man who has spent countless hours in court, *The Indian Express*

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

EXPRESS special

NO CHARGE ON CONSUMER, PERSON-TO-PERSON PAYMENTS

UPI free for citizens, merchants may face 'nominal' fee: Govt

The charges for merchants, if and when applied, will be lower than that for debit or credit cards: Ministry

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, August 8

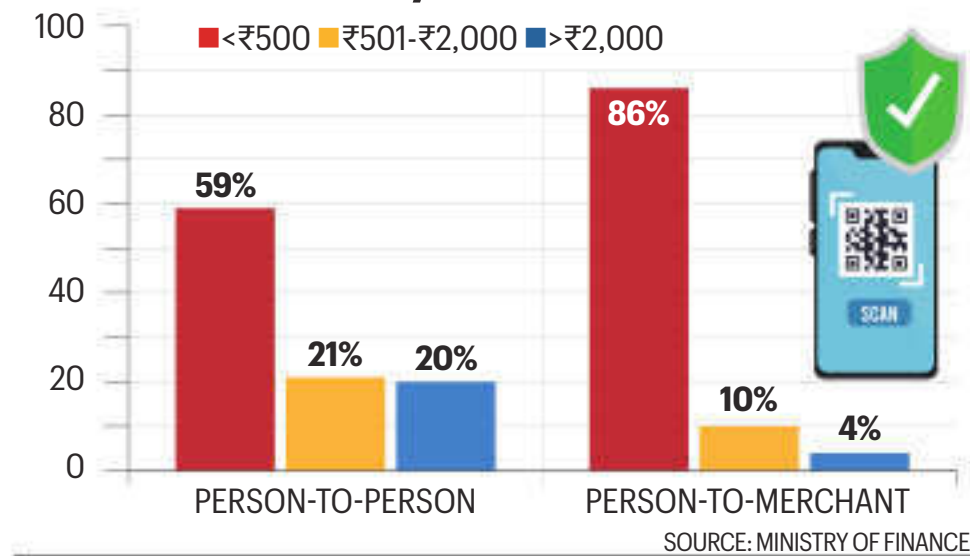
ALLAYING USER concerns, the Ministry of Finance "categorically" stated Saturday that consumers making UPI payments will not face any transaction charges, and all person-to-person transactions will continue to be free of charge.

It, however, said as and when MDR (Merchant Discount Rate) charges are introduced, they will apply at a nominal rate only above a certain threshold, and on a limited set of merchant transactions. "It would be far lower than debit or credit card MDRs," the statement said.

MDR is a fee levied on merchants by banks to help meet costs related to processing of transactions, settlement and infrastructure. Credit cards face

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

UPI transactions by ticket size in FY26



Why charge? Because smooth UPI payments cost Rs 20,000 cr a year

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, August 8

SHOPPING HAS never been easier or cheaper since the Unified Interface Payments, launched in 2016, democratised finance and QR codes replaced complex bank details for transactions big and small. Today, consumers don't pay for it, nor do merchants.

The costs are being paid for by banks and other financial system players, and estimates suggest these to be about Rs 20,000 crore a year now.

Banks expected to get compensated after all this when the Lok Sabha passed The Taxation and Other Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026 on Thursday.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

INDIAN EXPRESS UPSC IAS EDITION HD 09~08~2026

-:FOR UPSC IAS ASPIRANTS:-

"AVOID POLITICAL & IRRELEVANT ARTICLES"

Please Try To Read This Completely in 40 Minutes If You Can't So Then You Have To Increase Your Efforts

All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or indirectly important for the prelims & main examination. There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing of other topics in the main exam.

No drop-down options, caste census format to be open-ended

Enumerators to record caste stated by people, will not try to classify surnames, sub-castes into broader caste categories

Deeptiman Tiwary
New Delhi, August 8

THE REGISTRAR General of India (RGI) has decided to use an "open-ended question on caste" rather than a drop-down menu of castes for the caste census to be conducted alongside the population enumer-

ation phase of the Census.

This format is likely to produce results similar to the 2011 exercise when the Socio-Economic and Caste Census (SECC) was conducted.

Sources in the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) said enumerators will simply ask people to state their caste and record the

answer verbatim, without attempting to classify surnames, sub-castes or other responses into broader caste categories.

Population enumeration, along with the caste census, will be conducted across the country in February next year. However, in hilly and snow-bound areas,

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Round 2 of talks

hunger strike.

The controversy began soon after the Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC) declared the preliminary examination results of the 14th Combined Civil Services Examination on July 2. The Commission shortlisted 2,204 candidates against 103 vacancies, but allegations of irregularities emerged soon after. Around 3.5 lakh people took the exam.

At the heart of the protest, which comes against the back-drop of the developments at New Delhi's Jantar Mantar, are allegations of paper leaks in the exam. The Soren government has tried to act quickly – 19 people have been arrested, and the Chief Minister has said they stand with the youth – but the protests have shown no signs of slowing.

On Saturday, an eight-member delegation of the JPSC-JSSC Abhyarthi Nyay Manch left the protest site at Ranchi's Jaipal Singh Munda Stadium and reached a guesthouse in Morabadi around 10:30 am for the meeting. The talks began around 11:30 am.

The delegation reiterated the demands already put forward by another platform that has emerged during the protests, the JPSC-JSSC Reform Manch, which held talks with the government on Friday night. Saturday's meeting also saw some additional demands concerning candidates from different recruitment tests, including issues related to the TGT examination and other teacher recruitment examinations.

The government side was represented by Sudivya Kumar Sonu (JMM), Chamra Linda (JMM), Deepika Singh Pandey (Congress), and Sanjay Yadav (RJD).

After the meeting, Sonu addressed the media and appealed to students and candidates to send their suggestions and views to the government through a dedicated email so that their concerns could be considered.

Student representative Chandan Rajak said their demands would now be taken forward to Chief Minister Soren. "Only after a decision is taken will we move away from the hunger strike and the agitation," Rajak said.

Meanwhile, the crowd continued to swell at Jaipal Singh Munda Stadium. Two students sitting on hunger strike were taken to Sadar Hospital after their health deteriorated, while several other protesters were also reported to be unwell.

Students from both key outfits have said they plan to march towards the Assembly for a gherrao on August 10.

The ruling JMM's students' wing, the Jharkhand Chhatra Morcha (JCM), has also placed five demands before the government panel, including the cancellation of the 14th JPSC examination. The NSUI has placed six demands before the government, including a CID probe into all JPSC and JSSC examinations under suspicion within 90 days and the establishment of the Jharkhand Testing Agency on the lines of the National Testing Agency. – WITH INPUTS FROM PTI

Why charge

The Bill proposed changes to the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007, that could allow banks and payment system providers to charge fees on UPI and RuPay debit card payments.

These fees, called the Merchant Discount Rate (MDR), would have to be paid by the seller, not buyers. Using UPI will remain free and no MDR will be applicable on money transferred from one person to another, or P2P transactions.

Other payment mechanisms too carry costs. The Reserve Bank of India, for instance, spends around Rs 5,000 crore a year to print currency notes. Cards are paid for by the issuer and costs are recovered from the user — public sector banks charged as much as Rs 7,564 crore for annual maintenance of debit cards in 2025-26, up from

UPI free for citizens

an MDR of 1-3% of transaction value while it is up to 0.9% for debit cards.

The Finance Ministry's statement comes amid a raging debate over a potential fee on UPI payments after the government introduced The Taxation and Other Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026 in Parliament. Passed by the Lok Sabha on Thursday, the Bill proposes changes to the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007, which open the door for banks and payment system providers to charge fees on UPI and RuPay debit card payments.

The Bill led to fears that merchants which may face MDR charges in the future will pass on the cost to consumers. On Friday, the Payments Council of India (PCI) had clarified that consumers will not have to pay extra while making UPI transactions to large merchants.

In its statement, the Finance Ministry said the amendment to the taxation Bill has been misinterpreted "as a move to impose charges on ordinary users".

Two days after the Bill was introduced, Congress leader Jairam Ramesh on Thursday said in a post on social media platform X that the cost of the MDR "will inevitably be borne by ordinary people who will now have to pay to use UPI transactions".

Responding to his post, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman had said the UPI and Services Steering Committee, headed by the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI), is yet to make a decision. In its statement, the Finance

Ministry said "vast majority" of UPI transactions will remain free of charge for merchants and an MDR, "if introduced, will only be threshold based and not blanketly levied to all".

According to a poll of more than 20,000 people by social media polling company LocalCircles, only 2% of respondents said they would continue using UPI if merchants were to recover any transaction fee from customers for UPI payments of more than Rs 3,000.

Since its launch in April 2016, UPI has democratised finance in India with QR codes replacing complex bank details for money transfers. In 2025-26, there were more than 24,000 crore transactions (30% more than the previous year) worth Rs 314 lakh crores (21% more). Today, it is the world's largest real-time payment system.

In its statement, the Finance Ministry said to expand UPI further into rural and semi-urban areas and maintain competitiveness, it must be self-sustainable and affordable. "Reliance on subsidies alone is not viable for the next wave of growth. A balanced framework is required to ensure that UPI remains robust, inclusive, and future-ready."

For this, Jairam Ramesh had said Thursday that the Reserve Bank of India could fund the UPI ecosystem — with no charge on merchants and consumers — considering the central bank transferred Rs 2.86 lakh crore to the Centre as dividend for 2025-26.

The government has been subsidising UPI payments of up to Rs 2,000 made to only small merchants through its 'Incentive scheme for promotion of RuPay Debit Cards and low-value BHIM-UPI transactions (P2M)'. The incentive offered is capped at 0.15% of the transaction value and is shared between banks, payment service providers and third-party app providers.

The Centre paid out Rs 8,730 crore under the incentive scheme from 2021-22 to 2024-25. However, this was only 11% of the cost incurred by the payment industry, according to a report by the Standing Committee on Finance.

Congress' Jairam Ramesh had also expressed concerns in his August 6 post that the amendment follows a report by the US Trade Representative criticising UPI and RuPay "for being free and accuses them of having driven out American payment platforms like Visa and MasterCard".

The Finance Ministry said any suggestion that "external influences may be driving policy changes" is "unfounded, completely false and misleading".

The USTR, in its National Trade Estimate Report for 2026, had said the US had continued to raise concerns "relating to informal and formal policies with respect to electronic payments services that appear to favour Indian domestic suppliers over foreign suppliers, creating a non-level playing field". Specifically, it noted that US electronic payment services suppliers were unable to participate in the UPI ecosystem, including credit transactions on UPI, like RuPay could.

It also mentioned the 30% market share cap, in terms of the number of UPI transactions, for third-party apps. Originally to come into force in January 2023, the implementation of this cap has been deferred multiple times and the current deadline is December 2026. This cap is crucial as Walmart-owned PhonePe and Google Pay together handle almost 80% of all UPI transactions.

Payments industry experts have said in recent days that small merchants such as kirana stores would not have to pay any MDR fee.

In 2025-26, only 4% of person-to-merchant (P2M) UPI payments were greater than Rs 2,000. However, these 4% of transactions made up around two-thirds of UPI payments by value.

The Taxation and Other Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026, seeks to amend Section 10A of the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007, such that the exemption from any bank charges to electronic payments under section 269SU of the Income-tax Act, 1961 is removed.

Section 269SU applies to every person having an annual business turnover of over Rs 50 crore. It is this threshold that may be used to determine which merchants face an MDR, said payments industry executives. Some experts, however, said it could be lower at Rs 1 crore-Rs 1.5 crore.

Section 10A of the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007 says no bank or system provider can impose any charge on payments made through electronic modes prescribed under Section 269SU. These modes are RuPay debit cards, BHIM-UPI, and UPI-QR code.

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Caste census format

the exercise will begin from September 1 this year to avoid difficulties during the winter months.

"It has been finally decided that no dropdown menu or any other means will be used for caste enumeration. People have to just state their caste and the same will be recorded as it is. Enumerators are not supposed to categorise any surname or sub-caste in a caste category. Things will be recorded verbatim," a senior MHA official said.

The decision comes after the RGI considered using a dropdown menu drawing from the Central and State lists of castes, particularly for Other Backward Classes (OBCs). The Census already uses a drop-down menu for recording notified Scheduled Caste (SC) and Scheduled Tribe (ST) communities.

The "open-ended question on caste" method was exactly how the 2011 Socio-Economic and Caste Census (SECC) was conducted. The exercise failed to produce usable caste data largely because of poor data quality, the absence of a standardized caste registry and flaws in operational design. Since respondents could self-report caste names without verification, the exercise generated an administrative nightmare.

The final dataset contained nearly 46.7 lakh distinct caste names, compared with the 4,147 castes recorded in the last comprehensive caste census in 1931. The Union government eventually withheld the raw caste data.

"Yes, it is true that an open-ended question will likely produce 2011-like results. But what can we do? We have always

maintained that a caste census is fraught with possibilities of producing poor data because of the complexities involved. But the Opposition has been demanding it for political reasons. We have accepted it. Let them deal with the final data," a Union Minister said.

The government, however, maintains that an open-ended response is the only way to conduct the exercise without the State itself becoming an arbiter of caste identities.

Under the proposed system, an enumerator will record what a respondent says rather than determine whether the answer corresponds to a recognised caste, sub-caste or category.

"Census is not a verification exercise, only a recording exercise. It does not ask for evidence against your claims. If a Brahmin claims he is a Yadav, the enumerator is not going to ask for his caste certificate. Creating a dropdown menu thus will create a situation of state participation in unreliable data," the MHA official said.

The decision also addresses a concern raised by the RSS and sections of the Sangh Parivar over the use of existing Central and State caste lists. They had argued that relying on such lists could further entrench what they view as a caste architecture institutionalised under British rule.

The choice of an open-ended format, however, leaves the government with the problem that had complicated the 2011 exercise: how to convert millions of individual responses into reliable, standardised caste data without appearing to determine or alter what respondents have reported.

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6

37 MPs, INCLUDING THOSE FROM DMK & AIADMK, BOYCOTT MEET

Vijay-led MPs' meet seeks permanent freeze on LS seats

Arun Janardhanan
Chennai, August 8

A MEETING of Tamil Nadu MPs convened by Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay Saturday called for permanently freezing the strength of the Lok Sabha at 543 and preserving each state's existing share of parliamentary representation, even as most of the state's MPs stayed away amid an escalating political dispute over delimitation.

Only 20 of Tamil Nadu's 57 MPs — 39 in Lok Sabha and 18 in Rajya Sabha — attended the meeting. Thirty-seven MPs boycotted it, including those from DMK and AIADMK. PMK, DMDK and MNM also stayed away, while MPs belonging to the Congress, VCK, CPI, CPI(M), IUML and MDMK participated.

The meeting resolved that the TN government should bring a resolution in the Assembly urging the Centre not to proceed with delimitation and instead extend the existing freeze



TN CM C Joseph Vijay expressed displeasure over the absence of DMK & AIADMK. PTI FILE

on number of LS seats. Such a resolution is likely to be introduced in Assembly next week.

“Since the delimitation exercise will reduce Tamil Nadu’s representation and importance, it is imperative that MPs work in unison to protect the state’s right,” Vijay was quoted as saying in an official release.

MPs who attended the meeting said Vijay also expressed displeasure over absence of DMK and AIADMK.

The participants rejected suggestions that increasing the

strength of LS could address the concerns of southern states, describing a possible 50% expansion as an “illusion intended to sweeten the pill.” Their position goes further: Parliament should remain at 543 elected LS seats, and the relative representation of states should not change.

The boycott, however, exposed the political divisions surrounding an issue on which TN's parties broadly agree: states that successfully reduced population growth should not lose political influence.

DMK parliamentary party leader Kanimozhi Karunanidhi called Vijay's meeting a "political drama" intended to divert attention from Cauvery dispute and proposed Mokedatu dam. She said the DMK's position had already been settled through an earlier all-party process initiated by ex-CM MK Stalin. AIADMK similarly argued that Vijay should have called party leaders for an all-party meeting rather than separately inviting MPs.

JD Vance dials Modi, discusses ways to expand India-US ties

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, August 8

US VICE PRESIDENT J D Vance dialled Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday to discuss expanding the India-US comprehensive global strategic partnership, amid rising tensions in West Asia.

During the conversation, the PM extended his congratulations to Vance and Second Lady Usha on the birth of their son. Vance's call to the PM came days after Turkey, Saudi Arabia and Pakistan signed a mutual defence pact that was widely seen as a reflection of a new regional alignment amid the West Asia conflict.

"Received a phone call from US Vice President JD Vance. We discussed ways to further deepen India-US Comprehensive Global Strategic Partnership across key areas," Modi said on social media. "Warmly congratulated him and the Second Lady on the birth of their son and conveyed best wishes to the entire family."

The American side has not yet provided any details of the conversation. It is not immediately known whether the proposed trade deal between India and the US figured in the talks.

Modi and US President Donald Trump, during their meeting in France in June, instructed their officials to work towards a balanced, mutually beneficial and commercially meaningful trade agreement at the earliest.

'Free movement for all': Manipur govt reopens national highways after 3 yrs

Jimmy Leivon
Imphal, August 8

IN A significant development, the Manipur government on Saturday announced the immediate reopening of the state's national highways, allowing the free movement of people from all communities.

The announcement was made jointly by Chief Minister Yumnam Khemchand Singh, his deputy Nemcha Kipgen, and legislator Haokholet Kipgen at the Kangpokpi District Headquarters.

The state's two key lifelines, namely NH-37 (Imphal-Jiribam road) and NH-2 (Imphal-Dimapur road), have been severely affected by law-and-order challenges and blockades since the



Members of Naga and Meitei communities burn tyres on NH-2 during a protest over the death of six Naga civilians in Leilon Vaiphei village in June this year, in Kangpokpi on Saturday. ANI

outbreak of the ethnic violence on May 3, 2023. Their reopening is expected to instill life in the battle-weary state. The govern-

ment has also declared the resumption of the Imphal-Dimapur bus service.

During a public address in Kangpokpi, Singh said that the boundaries of Manipur were shaped and protected by all communities, who have made sacrifices to safeguard the state's integrity. He also said that it was unfortunate that certain vested interests were trying to create confusion among the public, but added that every crisis has a solution.

Further, Singh urged all communities to build trust and support one another. He said that people should first identify themselves as Indians and then as Manipuris, expressing concern that some were not hesitant to do the latter.

He also pointed out that India's development would remain incomplete without the progress of the Northeast, and

similarly, Manipur's development would be incomplete without the development of Kangpokpi district.

In hailing the occasion as a historic moment for the state, Deputy Chief Minister Kipgen on Saturday said that balanced development between the valley and hill areas is essential for the state's overall progress, adding that the BJP-led government has been consistently working for the development of Manipur.

She also pointed out that lasting peace can be achieved only through mutual trust, love, and understanding among communities, and sought the support of civil society organisations, public leaders, intellectuals, and all stakeholders in building enduring peace in Manipur.

Kerala govt makes cause of death medical certificate mandatory

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, August 8

THE KERALA government recently made Medical Certification Of Cause Of Death, or MCCD, mandatory for all deaths registered in the state.

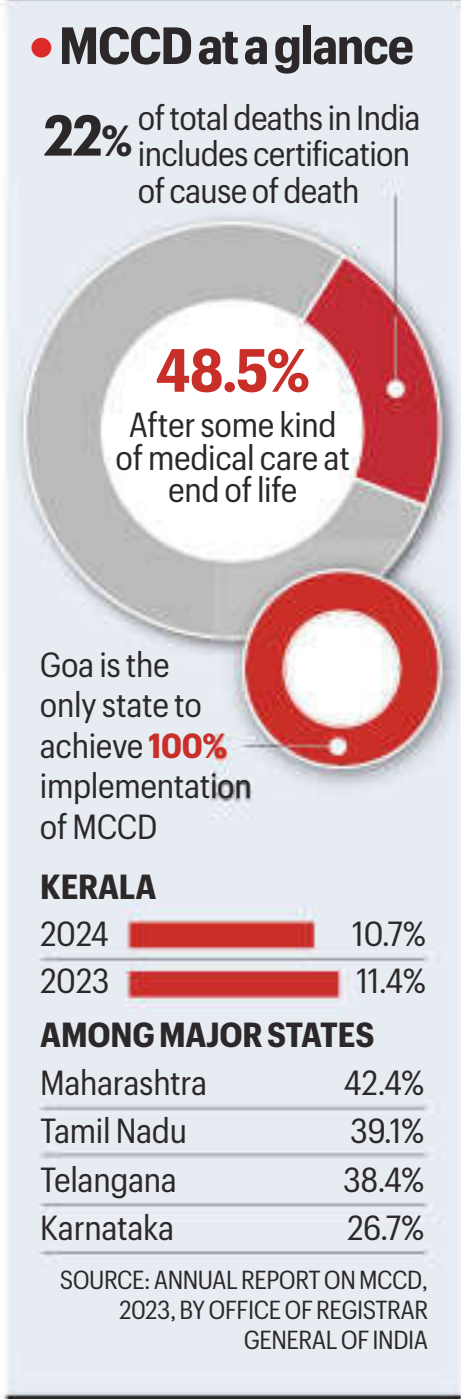
According to Divya S Iyer, principal director of the local self-government department (LSGD), this course of action has been implemented in all 93 urban local bodies in the state since June 1, following an order issued on May 28. So far, the MCCD scheme has been implemented in four of the six corporations (Kochi, Thiruvananthapuram, Kollam and Kozhikode), and Alappuzha municipality were registered and certified.

"The scope of MCCD has been expanded considering its importance to public health. We have activated the civil registration system in all urban bodies (6 corporations and 87 municipalities) to incorporate the Certificate Of Cause Of Death while registering deaths, both institutional and at home," Divya said.

The MCCD is a key document that informs public health policy formation, disease surveillance, medical research and allied activities. In another two months, the 940-odd village panchayats, too, will follow the practice of making medical certification of cause of death mandatory, Divya highlighted. So far, the system has not thrown up major hitches. However, it was noticed that there is a delay in certifying deaths wherein a postmortem report is necessary to ascertain the cause.

Divya also pointed out that while the medical certification of institutional deaths is seamless in the new system, "certain issues have to be addressed with regard to certifying deaths at home." A meeting will soon be arranged with all stakeholders to remedy this.

In Kerala, the medical certification of cause of death under the new directive has been integrated with the Information Ke-



MONTHS AFTER GUJARAT EDUCATION DEPARTMENT LAUNCHES 'BACK TO SCHOOL' CAMPAIGN

Ahmedabad records 86% success in bringing back dropouts

Ritu Sharma
Ahmedabad, August 8

NEETABEN N Bhadresha (44), a head teacher at a municipal school in Ahmedabad's Vasna, spent her summer vacation going from home to home and tracking down 57 children who dropped out of her school in the past year. This meant making repeated visits on her scooter, convincing parents to not view their children as "earning members" and pull them out of schools.

It pained her to see former students helping their parents sell vegetables on the streets near Jivraj Mehta Hospital in the evenings. These 57 children dropped out from classes 1-8 from her school during the 2025-26 academic session. At the end of the 'Back to School' campaign launched by the State Education Department in May-June 2026, all the children returned to school.

"Apart from selling vegetables, children would go to

the wholesale market with their parents in the morning to buy them. So, they would miss both the morning as well as the evening classes," Bhadresha tells *The Indian Express*. "While children were ready to attend school, it was the parents who were insisting that they help them in their work."

Bhadresha heads Vasna Municipal Primary School Number 3. A veteran, she had spent 12 years at a municipal school in Kankaria before she joined here 18 months ago. The school runs a morning shift for classes 1-5 and evening for classes 6-8.

The government had identified over 6.41 lakh students who had dropped out in the past academic year, across 44,000 government and grant-in-aid schools in Gujarat, and launched a campaign to re-enroll them. In Ahmedabad, after the teachers' dogged tracking of school dropouts, 9,036 from 10,387 enrolled back — recording an 86% success rate for the drive. The



Paresh Patel (extreme right), a teacher at Indrapuri Public School in Ramol area of Ahmedabad, had 44 dropouts to track. EXPRESS

number includes 1,357 former students who had enrolled in schools in other states or in Industrial Training Institutes (ITIs) and continued their education.

Every teacher faced a different obstacle. In the case of Suketubhai Yagnik, teacher at Jahangirpura Primary School in Asarwa area, over 80% of his 37 students were girls who dropped out. When he visited homes of the six girl students who had dropped out of Class 8, their parents told him they

needed the elder daughter to take care of younger siblings or do chores around the house.

"Parents are of the opinion that after a certain age, girls should not go out and study. Instead, they train them in household work such as stocking water, cutting vegetables, cooking, cleaning and washing. They even teach a 6-7 year old girl all these tasks," Yagnik says, adding, "When everything else would fail, at that point we would make parents aware about government schemes, especially for girls. Yet parents cited social constraints and would refuse to send them back."

Asarwa locality, where this school is, largely comprises migrants who have made Ahmedabad their home. Known for textile mills decades ago, now it is better known for the Ahmedabad Civil Hospital — the largest public hospital in Gujarat. Municipal teachers here were asked to cover a 30-35 km radius, given that most parents would move frequently to find work.

For Yagnik and other teachers, the task grew difficult as the families were vegetable vendors or daily wagers living in rented quarters or temporary structures. "We would find them the first time, but they would be gone in the second. The contact number and addresses submitted during the admission process became irrelevant. Every 3-4 months, they would keep changing their numbers as most of the time

they do not recharge their mobile numbers," says Yagnik.

Sanjay Raval, principal of Chanakya Gujarati Primary school in Chanakyapuri, says, "Migration is a big issue among parents in our school. A majority of them are from Rajasthan and a few from different districts of Gujarat. Around 80% of them are into footwear-making work, while those from Gujarat are mainly *safai kamdars*." It is one of the seven schools in Ahmedabad city that also has a secondary school launched last year. Of 54 students re-enrolled under Raval, seven who had dropped out after Class 8 were readmitted in Class 11.

Ahmedabad Municipal School Board Administrative Officer L D Desai said, "Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel felicitated our teachers on July 22 for achieving a high success rate in bringing back the dropped out students."

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

rala Mission, the state government venture giving IT services from local bodies.

The MCCD is the official legal and medical document that states the exact sequence of medical conditions and events leading to a person's death.

Under sections 10(2) and 10(3) of the Registration of Births and Deaths (Amendment) Act, 1969, it is stipulated that for all deaths occurring in medical institutions, the medical practitioner who treated the deceased must provide the registrar with a certificate regarding the cause of death in the prescribed format. In the case of deaths at home, the doctor who treated the persons during their terminal illness is required to report the cause of death.

As per official data, Goa is the only state to achieve 100% implementation of MCCD.

EXPRESS special

Mumbai to get sea-viewing deck, knowledge centre atop Bandra STP by next July

Pratip Acharya
Mumbai, August 8

IN JULY next year, Mumbai is set to get a new sea-viewing deck offering an unhindered view of the Arabian Sea and a new public space for citizens to enjoy the city’s skyline, particularly during sunset hours.

The viewing deck, currently under construction, will be located at the southern edge of Bandra, adjoining the Bandra-Worli Sea Link (BWSL).

At present, Mumbai has two dedicated sea-viewing decks, at Dadar and Girgaon in the island city. The proposed facility will therefore be the first such deck in Mumbai’s suburban belt.

Along with the viewing deck, the project will create an additional 2.6 acres of open space — a significant addition in space-starved Mumbai.

These amenities are part of the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation’s (BMC) ambitious Wastewater Treatment Facility (WWTF) project. Under the project, the civic body plans to construct seven sewage treatment

• WHAT THE PROJECT ENTAILS

2,600 sq m
Size of Knowledge Centre

2.6 acres
Area of open garden

FEATURES OF THE GARDEN

The open space will include walkways, gym equipment and seating areas. A skywalk will connect the garden with the viewing deck and convention centre.

LOCATION: Western side of the Bandra-Worli Sea Link and at the southern end of Bandra.

VIEW: 360-degree view of the Arabian Sea & Mumbai’s skyline.

plants (STPs) at Bandra, Worli, Dharavi, Ghatkopar, Bhandup, Versova and Malad.

In 2023, the BMC initiated the WWTF project at an estimated cost of Rs 30,000 crore. The seven STPs, which are



- | | | |
|--|--|--|
| 1 Knowledge Center & Viewing Gallery, | 5 Preliminary Treatment, | 10 Effluent Pumping Station (Existing), |
| 2 Admin Building, | 6 Sludge Treatment Area, | 11 Digesters, |
| 3 Disinfection, | 7 IIPS, 8 Membrane Tank, 9 Bio Treatment, | 12 Power Generation Building. |

FEATURES OF THE TOWER:

The 60-metre tower will house a knowledge centre, auditorium & convention centre on lower deck.

KNOWLEDGE CENTRE:

Provides details on Mumbai’s history of water conservation and on how BMC provides amenities.

PROJECT DEADLINE: JULY 2027 COST: RS 65.76 CR

will create an additional open area of around two acres, which the civic authorities are converting into a green and recreational zone. The landscaped area will include gardens, walkways and recreational facilities such as outdoor gym and seating areas.

At the Bandra facility, adjoining the recreational area, BMC is constructing a 60-metre-high tower that will be divided into multiple sections. The ground, first and second floors will house an auditorium, convention hall and information centre.

“The WWTF project is a unique venture of the BMC and today engineering students from reputed educational institutions are carrying out field visits at our sites. Therefore, the BMC decided to create a knowledge centre at this site about these STPs,” an official said.

According to the civic officials, the auditorium and convention hall will be equipped with a modern library, digital classrooms, auditorium-style seating and digitally integrated study desks.

daily water requirement.

The Bandra STP will be equipped with a bioreactor unit, where the primary treatment of sewage will take place.

The terrace of the reactor, which will be at the ground level,

scheduled to become operational in phases between the end of 2026 and 2027, will have a combined capacity to treat and recycle 2,400 million litres of water daily (MLD). This is equivalent to around 55% of Mumbai’s

On rural jobs, the 60:40 dilemma



OFF THE RECORD
BY P VAIDYANATHAN IYER

NO STATE likes it when the Centre asks it to share a burden it never did in the past. More so in these times, when political parties have, in a race to the bottom, made fiscally unsustainable promises to win Assembly elections.

Naturally then, states, particularly those ruled by the Opposition, threw a fit after the Centre suddenly changed the rules of the game and asked them this year to partly provide for the big-ticket National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme. For 20 long years, all states were happy when it was fully funded by the Centre — in the first 10 years by the UPA government after it launched the scheme in 2006, and later by the NDA government.

Under the scheme, now rechristened as Viksit Bharat - Guarantee for Rozgar and Aajeevika Mission (Gramin) or VB-G RAM-G, if a state requires Rs 100 crore in a year, the Centre will give Rs 60 crore from the Union Budget, and the state will give Rs 40 crore

from the state Budget. For Himalayan and Northeastern states, the Centre-state split is 90:10; for Union Territories without legislatures, the Centre will fully fund the scheme. Earlier, the Centre provided the entire amount of wages for all states.

It is not just the Opposition, but also those where the BJP is in power, which feel the fiscal stress of the change in rules. They, too, complain, but in private, because the resource kitty is limited, significant expenditure remains sticky and inflexible, and they, too, have to make tough choices on how and where to spend the scarce revenues they earn.

The opposition to the Centre's move is not just political, but social, economic and fiscal too. Political, understandably, because this was a flagship scheme introduced by the Congress but never seen as transformative by the BJP. Social, since it offered livelihood and a minimum income security to poor farmers and labourers who could not get any other job. Economic, because the NREGA wage acted like a floor, and NREGA job card holders leveraged it to deny work offers with wages lower than this. Fiscal, because states are perpetually strapped for cash.

While the Finance Ministers of BJP states have little choice but to toe the national party line, those of Opposition states — Karnataka, Kerala, Telangana, Punjab, Tamil Nadu and Jharkhand — spoke out. In Budget speech after speech, they condemned the Centre for requiring them to take care of 40% expendi-

Given the states' opposition to the funding pattern of VB-G RAM-G, why would they make budget allocations? One, they have little choice. But more importantly, it is true the scheme has transformed the way the rural economy works

ture. Some wanted the Centre to uphold the principles of decentralised governance and rights of rural workers, others demanded restoration of 100% funding, and yet others threatened legal recourse.

In his March 20 Budget speech, Telangana Finance Minister Bhatti Vikramarka Mallu said: "This is not just a scheme; it is an 'employment right' provided to the common person. Over the past two decades, this scheme has brought about a silent revolution in villages." Then Karnataka CM Siddaramaiah, who also held the Finance portfolio, was more frontal in his attack. "Our Government remains committed to pursuing all appropriate recourse, including legal measures, to safeguard the rights of rural workers and uphold the principles of decentralised governance," he said in his March 6 Budget speech. Every other Opposition state i.e., Tamil Nadu, Himachal Pradesh, Jharkhand, Punjab and Kerala, said the rule change is not right, and hurts rural worker's interests.

All this makes for good optics in the political theatre. But despite the restrictions and new funding pattern, Opposition states have embraced realpolitik, and for good reasons. This shows in their budget allocation for VB-G RAM-G scheme in this financial year. In his Budget speech on August 5, Tamil Nadu Finance Minister N Marie Wilson said the state has made an "unprecedented" contribution of Rs 5,057 crore. This translates to exactly 40% of the total VB-G

RAM-G budget of Rs 12,642 crore for the state in 2026-27. Three other states provided 40% of their share: Karnataka Rs 3,806.61 crore (40% of Rs 9,516 crore), Telangana Rs 2,550.21 crore (40% of Rs 6,375 crore) and Jharkhand Rs 1,853 crore (40% of Rs 4,558 crore). Tamil Nadu, in fact, went a step ahead and said it will provide 150 days employment (25 days more than the VB-G RAM-G scheme) by bearing an extra expenditure of Rs 100 crore.

Kerala Chief Minister VD Satheesan said he has allocated Rs 1,422 crore; this is just 27% of the Rs 5,226 crore VB-G RAM-G total estimated budget for the state) in the first phase, Punjab Rs 608 crore (27% of Rs 2,218 crore total estimated budget), and Himachal Rs 50.94 crore (4% of Rs 1,337 crore as against the required 10%). It is pretty certain states will provide fully for it during the course of the year.

Given such strident opposition, why would all states do it? One, they have little choice. But more importantly, it is true the scheme has transformed the way the rural economy works, providing not just employment security, but wage security too. Nobody quite bothers about the Minimum Wages Act. But for this scheme, rural wages in states will collapse. States are, at the end of the day, putting their money where their mouth is.

The writer is Managing Editor,
The Indian Express.
Off the Record is a fortnightly column

IRGC SAYS U.S. ACCEPTANCE OF TEHRAN'S CONDITIONS KEY TO REOPENING THE STRAIT

Iran: Hormuz deal with Oman near, reopening hinges on US concessions

UAE says Tehran struck a ship in strait with a missile

Reuters
Cairo, Washington, Riyadh, August 8

IRAN SAID on Saturday that a deal with Oman on control of the Strait of Hormuz was close but would not be enough to free up the waterway, and the United Arab Emirates said Iran had hit another ship there.

Agreement between Iran and Oman over the strait is seen as vital to a wider deal to end the war that began with US and Israeli attacks on Iran on February 28 and led to Tehran establishing a chokehold over the major energy export route.

A US official, who declined to be identified, had said on Friday that Washington anticipated an agreement soon between Iran and Oman, which sit on either side of the strait, so that normal oil traffic could resume.

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araqchi said Iran and Oman were "very close" to agreement on a new shipping route through the strait but that reopening it depended on other conditions, including US com-



People gather on beach as commercial ships anchor off Bandar Abbas in Iran on Saturday. AP

pensation to Iran.

The secretary of Iran's top national security body, Mohammad Bagher Zolqadr, listed other demands including ending US threats against Iran, stopping aggression against Iran and its Lebanese, Palestinian, Yemeni and Iraqi allies, lifting a blockade and sanctions on Iran and freeing Iranian assets.

Oman condemned what it described as repeated attacks on vessels while transiting the strait, without assigning blame, and said that negotiations with Iran on arrangements for shipping through Hormuz were

"positive and constructive".

"Oman stresses the importance of avoiding any actions that could affect these negotiations and the progress achieved in a manner that takes into account the interests of all parties," the foreign ministry said.

Araghchi said the previous shipping traffic separation scheme through the strait was no longer acceptable to Tehran and that Iran was discussing a temporary route with Oman while technical and legal issues surrounding a permanent route were resolved.

Iran's President Masoud Pe-

zeshkian, a relative moderate, said he believed now was the best time for an agreement.

"There is cohesion, strength, and unity in the country, and as far as I know, Iran is considered victorious and powerful in this war," Iranian news agencies quoted him as saying.

Iran has responded to the US attacks by targeting US bases in Gulf states and Jordan as well as striking shipping in the strait.

The UAE said on Saturday that Iran had attacked a carrier affiliated with its state oil company with a missile as it transited the Strait of Hormuz, with no in-

juries reported, in the latest escalation in attacks on shipping there. There was no comment from Iranian authorities.

In recent weeks, the Trump administration has repeatedly signalled that a deal to open the strait could be close, only to have Iran deny that talks are under way. "Once the deal is announced to restore commercial shipping without impediments, the United States will lift the blockade of Iranian ports," the US official told *Reuters* on Friday. US actions would be tied to Iran's implementation of its commitments, he said.

Iran's Revolutionary Guards (IRGC), who have targeted ships, said on Saturday that reopening the Strait of Hormuz depended on Washington accepting Iran's conditions and was not related to the Iran-Oman negotiations.

"Whenever US accepts Iran's conditions, the Strait of Hormuz will certainly be reopened," said Guards spokesperson Hossein Mohebbi, according to Iran's *Tasnim* news agency.

A proposed deal between Iran and Oman to help the war between Iran and US would give Tehran control over ships entering the Gulf through strait, a senior Iranian source and two regional officials told *Reuters* Wednesday, one of the biggest concessions yet to Iran.

Yemen on brink of civil war as regional tensions mount

Ismaeel Naar
& Aaron Boxerman
Dubai, Jerusalem, August 8

THE INTERNATIONALLY recognized government of Yemen said its forces had retaliated on Saturday against Iran-backed Houthi rebels after days of attacks on the military, the latest in a surge of fighting that threatens to tip the country back into full-scale civil war.

The escalation reflected how the stability of the Middle East now hangs in the balance across multiple fronts. Despite

a lull in fighting between the United States and Iran, the region is waiting to learn whether a deal can be finalized to reopen the Strait of Hormuz, and stave off another round of conflict.

The Yemeni government's counteroffensive follows a rapid escalation that began two days ago, when the Houthis struck military positions in the oil and gas-rich provinces of Marib and Hadramout, killing at least 17 soldiers.

The violence persisted Friday, with Houthi attacks reported on civilian neighbor-

hoods and a sprawling displaced persons' camp near the city of Marib, killing two people and injuring 14 others, including children, according to Yemeni government.

On Saturday, Majed al-Nuzaili, a spokesman for Yemeni military, said that its forces had "carried out military action against terror elements" of the Houthi militia in several areas. He did not provide further details.

The Yemeni government, backed by Saudi Arabia, has been at war with the Houthis

since 2014, when the group seized Yemen's capital, Sanaa, with Iranian support. A year later, Saudi Arabia led a military coalition in support of the government, but its devastating bombing campaign ultimately failed to oust the Houthis from power.

Since then, Yemen has been effectively divided into two states, with the Houthis in control of large swaths of the north. Observers fear that a fragile truce hatched in 2022 has now all but collapsed. A sustained

Houthi push into Yemen's resource-rich eastern regions would threaten the government's economic lifeline and risk triggering a fresh humanitarian crisis among millions of vulnerable Yemenis.

The fighting in Yemen has taken on broader significance amid the war that the United States and Israel launched against Iran in late February.

The conflict prompted Iran's allies in the region, like the Houthis in Yemen and Hezbollah in Lebanon, to mount their own attacks. **NYT**

‘THE CENTRAL BANK WANTS TO BUY MORE TIME AS GROWTH, INFLATION TRAJECTORY IS NOT CLEAR’

‘RBI’s focus on core inflation is slightly confusing for markets’

INDIAN MARKETS have been left “confused” by the Reserve Bank of India’s (RBI’s) focus on inflation excluding food, fuel, and precious metals in its monetary policy decision on Wednesday, according to Murthy Nagarajan, Head of Fixed Income at Tata Asset Management. “RBI has said it is looking at headline inflation. But the language which has been used shows that it is looking at core inflation,” Nagarajan told **Siddharth Upasani** in an interview. He also discussed how the Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) may act in the future and Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) deposits possibly touching \$100 billion. *Edited excerpts:*

Do you agree with the view the RBI was unexpectedly dovish in its latest meeting?

Yes. Just a week ago, the governor gave an interview where he made similar statements. So, the market was expecting this to be a dovish policy. But the way in which he spoke on Wednesday was still a surprise. While he was expected to talk about inflation, he has changed the context. Now the general view is that the RBI is looking at core in-

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flation and core inflation excluding precious metals, which is projected to rise from around 2.5% and move towards 4%. If that is the case and 4% is the target, the feeling is that most probably in our view there will not be any rate hikes in 2026-27.

It is slightly confusing for the market. My reading is that because there is so much uncertainty, the RBI wants to keep the powder dry right now.

Moreover, FPI flows into debt have been strong and FCNR(B) inflows could be \$80 billion-\$90 billion at least and possibly touch \$100 billion. In this situation, there doesn’t seem to be a worry about forex. Back in February, the view was that Brent oil prices will go below \$70 per barrel. If we were to move towards that, should things clear up, then there may not be a need to hike rates. And if growth is strong, equity inflows can start coming back.

Is the MPC actually targeting core inflation excluding precious metals and the headline number is only a target on paper?

Yes. But, from the RBI’s perspective, it does not know when the war will end, there was a 40% rainfall deficit in June and



11% or so now. Oil prices are another uncertainty — so it is really difficult to take a call. It’s difficult to make predictions even in a normal environment.

I think the RBI also wants to defer its interest rate decision because if headline inflation is forecast to be above 5% for three consecutive quarters starting Q3 this year, then you should have hiked now — one year forward, inflation is projected at 5.3% and the repo rate is 5.25% right now. So, you are in a negative real interest rate territory. The only way you can justify that is by focusing on core inflation. Essentially, the RBI wants to buy more time because the growth and inflation trajectory is not clear. Ob-

viously, we are required to stabilise interest rates; whether it should be done now or after six months, that is the question. I think the RBI has taken a call that it’ll be prudent to do it after six months. They have first decided they don’t want to hike rates and then looked at the (reasons).

RBI has said it is looking at headline inflation. But the language which has been used shows that it is looking at core inflation. I think over the next 3-6 months they will start looking at headline inflation and make a decision.

Apart from the forecast of 5% plus inflation, the RBI’s assessment of growth is encouraging. And yet it is dovish. Is there some policy inconsistency?

For us sitting in India, it almost feels like there is no war going on: growth seems to be strong, fiscal deficit numbers look good, and there is strong credit growth — it does not feel like the first quarter of a financial year, when there is normally some slack.

I think the RBI has got time to normalise interest rates. They have said any excess liquidity will be taken out over

a period of time because it has a forward book of around \$100 billion right now. Forex reserves may be around \$692 billion, but \$100 billion of that is gold and another \$20 billion or so are the Special Drawing Rights and the Reserve Position in the IMF. You remove all that and it’s around \$550 billion. And you can’t have a forward position which is more than 20% of that; it can’t be that high.

If you want to control inflation, the best way is through money supply. I think the RBI will squeeze money supply if inflation goes above 5-5.5% and the operating rate may be 5.5-5.75% even if the repo rate stays at 5.25%. The RBI has the tools to do that. What also matters is the potential growth rate: is it 7% or 8%? Nobody knows, because the GDP series is new. If you think it’s 7.5-8%, then there is some amount of slack if you are growing at 6.7%, which is the RBI’s forecast for 2026-27.

If the RBI thinks there is some slack in the economy, then it may not have to hike rates as much and 50 bps in 2026-27 may be enough. I think it will start raising the repo rate in December.

FULL INTERVIEW ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Participation of mining operators sought to push uranium output

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, August 8

THE CENTRE should come up with a policy roadmap to ensure the participation of mine developer-cum-operators (MDO) in uranium mining, a Parliamentary committee has suggested, amid concerns that India’s domestic uranium production may not be enough to meet the future fuel requirements of its indigenous pressurised heavy water reactors (PHWRs).

The panel also recommended that any MDO participation in the sector should remain under the strict oversight of the Department of Atomic Energy (DAE). An MDO is a contractor engaged by the mine lease holder, typically a government or public-sector entity, to develop and operate the mine and undertake mining activities on its behalf. The recommendations comes at a time when the country seeks to expand its civil nuclear power capacity from the current 8.7 gigawatt-electric (GWe) to 100 GWe by 2047.

India’s indigenous PHWRs use natural uranium.

And their fuel requirements are currently met through a combination of domestic production from state-owned Uranium Corporation of India Ltd (UCIL) mines and imports. Enriched uranium used in the two light water reactor (LWR) variants — Tarapur Nuclear Power Plant and Kudankulam Nuclear Power Plant — is entirely imported.

UCIL, which alone has the mandate to mine and process uranium ore in the country, operates multiple underground and open-pit mines with processing plants in Jharkhand and Andhra Pradesh, and sends uranium concentrate to National Fuel Complex (NFC) for fuel fabrication for reactors operated by state-owned Nuclear Power Cor-

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● MINING ROADMAP

THE RECOMMENDATION by a Parliamentary Committee comes at a time when the country seeks to expand its civil nuclear power capacity from the current 8.7 GWe to 100 GWe by 2047

URANIUM CORPORATION of India Ltd (UCIL) alone has the mandate to mine and process uranium ore in the country

MINE DEVELOPER-cum-operator (MDO) is a contractor engaged by the mine lease holder, typically a government or public-sector entity, to develop and operate the mine and undertake mining activities on its behalf

poration of India Limited’s (NPCIL). “As per NPCIL’s capacity expansion trajectory, PHWRs alone could require approximately 5,400 tonnes U3O8 (uranium oxide, or yellowcake) per annum for about 25 GWe, while UCIL currently estimates catering to about 30% of this need,” the panel on public undertakings noted.

The panel said this would imply continued reliance on imports unless domestic uranium production is accelerated and supply sources are diversified.

‘Expedite acquisition global uranium assets’

The parliamentary panel also noted that India currently imports uranium from Kazakhstan, Russia, Uzbekistan and Canada, with the long-term supply contract with Uzbekistan valid until 2026. The panel sought an update on the government’s plans to secure long-term uranium supplies from Uzbekistan beyond 2026. “The Committee believes that establishing strategic uranium stockpiles, calibrated to refueling cycles and

outage risks, is essential to sustaining reactor operations during supply disruptions,” it noted.

The panel sought a comprehensive report from the DAE on the timelines for the UCIL-NTPC joint venture and plans for future fuel sourcing and the proposed framework for MDO participation in domestic uranium mining under DAE oversight. DAE also informed the panel that it is pursuing an amendment to the MMDR Act to allow a one-time extension of mining leases for uranium minerals by up to 10% of the existing lease area. The proposed change is aimed at addressing instances where newly identified or deeper extensions of ore bodies extend beyond existing lease boundaries.

Under the current framework, such extensions require separate leases and clearances, which can affect the techno-economic viability of projects, particularly for deposits located at depths beyond 600 metres. According to the panel, Atomic Minerals Directorate for Exploration and Research (AMD) has established about 4,31,000 tonnes of in-situ uranium oxide resources, but only about 80,423 tonnes have been transferred to UCIL under the provisions of Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Act (MMDR) and the Atomic Minerals Concession Rules.

Of this, 39.22% has already depleted, leaving about 60.78% currently available. At current production rates, these reserves can last about 40 years if no new reserves are added, it noted.

The panel also noted that UCIL faces challenges including ore body depth, low ore grades, land acquisition hurdles, public resistance and tailings management, which could affect production schedules.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

NBFC gold loan growth touches 69% in June, industry credit slows

ENS Economic Bureau
Mumbai, August 8

CREDIT AGAINST gold jewellery extended by non-banking financial companies (NBFCs) surged 69.3% year-on-year to Rs 3.41 lakh crore in June 2026, emerging as the fastest-growing major retail lending segment, according to data released by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI).

Gold-loan growth by NBFCs accelerated sharply from 40.6% in June 2025, even as overall credit growth by NBFCs, including housing finance companies (HFCs), rose to 14.4% in June 2026 from 11.1% a year earlier. The surge in gold prices has prompted people to pledge gold holdings for the finance requirements.

The RBI data show that outstanding credit extended by NBFCs stood at Rs 59.31 lakh crore at the end of June 2026, compared with Rs 51.86 lakh crore in June 2025.

The figures are based on a sample covering NBFCs in the Upper and Middle Layers and HFCs, accounting for about 87% of total NBFC credit.

Almost all NBFCs, led by Muthoot Finance, in the Upper Layer category of the RBI are active in the gold loan business.

Retail lending remained the key driver of the expansion, with growth accelerating to 20.3% in June 2026 from 14.35 a year earlier.

Outstanding retail credit increased to Rs 25.62 lakh crore from Rs 21.29 lakh crore, RBI said. Within retail lending, loans against gold jewellery recorded the sharpest growth at 69.3%.

Consumer durable loans also expanded rapidly, rising 46.8% year-on-year, while vehicle loans grew 15.2%. Housing



The surge in gold prices has prompted people to pledge gold holdings for the finance requirements. REUTERS

loans, including lending by HFCs, grew 11.4% to Rs 8.44 lakh crore.

The acceleration in retail lending was accompanied by stronger growth in credit to agriculture and allied activities. Credit to the sector grew 179% in June 2026, sharply up from 5.1% a year earlier. Outstanding credit to agriculture and allied activities stood at Rs 79,684 crore, RBI said.

In contrast, credit growth to industry moderated.

Industrial credit grew 6.7% year-on-year in June 2026, compared with 10.3% in June 2025. The moderation was primarily driven by subdued growth in infrastructure, the RBI said. Infrastructure credit grew 5.1% during the period, against 9.7% a year earlier.

Within infrastructure, credit to the power sector expanded 4.9%, it said.

Credit growth in the services sector also moderated, although it remained relatively

strong at 17.6% in June 2026, compared with 22.4% a year earlier. Commercial real estate was a notable exception, with credit rising 33.8% year-on-year to Rs 1.11 lakh crore.

Growth in credit to trade and transport operators, however, moderated to 17.1% and 9.8%, respectively.

The RBI data also showed a reversal in the “other loans” category, which grew 17.5% year-on-year in June 2026, compared with a contraction of 19.5% a year earlier.

The central bank said the sectoral credit data are provisional and based on information reported by the sampled entities on the last day of the month.

The sample covers NBFCs in the Upper and Middle Layers and HFCs and accounts for about 87% of total NBFC credit, based on the benchmark cited in the RBI’s Report on Trend and Progress of Banking in India 2024-25.

Govt examining Meta’s recommendation system

New Delhi: The Centre’s meetings with Meta have brought into focus a key question — whether the social media giant’s recommendation systems and paid content promotion fit in its status as an intermediary, government sources said adding the key issue is whether the company complies with the provisions under the IT Act or crosses into the role of a publisher by deciding “what content is shown to whom”.

Sources further said that the issue centres on whether a platform that actively decides what users see, can continue to claim intermediary status

under the Information Technology Act.

The issue assumes significance because Section 79 of the IT Act grants intermediaries a “safe harbour” from liability for third-party content, subject to compliance with the provisions of the law and due diligence requirements.

Sources said if Meta’s recommendation systems determine “what is shown to whom” and also “promote content for payment”, it raises the question of whether such functions are consistent with the legal definition of an intermediary. PTI

US Senate nod to Russia sanctions bill may hit Indian exports: GTRI

New Delhi: The US Senate’s approval of a bill on Russia sanctions could expose Indian exports to additional tariffs of up to 100% if India continues buying Russian crude oil, think tank GTRI said on Saturday.

The US Senate voted overwhelmingly to approve a bill to punish Russia and key buyers of its petroleum products, such as China and India, claiming that such trade helps fuel the Ukraine war.

This bill will allow US President Donald Trump to impose 100% tariffs on goods from countries that are the top five importers of Russian oil and gas. The GTRI said that India, being the second-largest buyer of Russian crude, is exposed to high tariffs. Russia supplied 30.3% of India’s crude imports in FY2026, worth \$40.8 billion, helping reduce costs and contain inflation.

“The US Senate has overwhelmingly approved legislation that could expose Indian exports to additional tariffs of up to 100% if India continues buying Russian crude oil,” it said. PTI

● THE SANTA FE COURT RULED ON THURSDAY THAT META MUST PAY \$567 MILLION INTO A NEW MEXICO FUND FOR TEEN MENTAL HEALTH PREVENTION AND TREATMENT

How New Mexico’s \$567 million ruling could reshape Meta’s platforms

Reuters
New York, August 8

A NEW Mexico state court ordered Meta Platforms, owner of Facebook and Instagram, to make major changes to its platforms and pay the largest sum yet in a growing wave of US litigation over claims that social media harms young people.

Here is a look at the decision and its potential consequences.

How much must Meta pay?

The court in Santa Fe ruled on Thursday that Meta must pay \$567 million into a New Mexico fund for teen mental health pre-

vention and treatment.

In an earlier phase of the case, a jury awarded New Mexico \$375 million on related consumer protection claims.

The combined \$942 million far exceeds other penalties in youth-related social media cases including a \$6 million verdict against Meta and Alphabet’s, Google, owner of YouTube, in a California case in March.

Meta said the claims misrepresented the facts and that it will appeal the ruling.

What did the court order Meta to change?

Judge Bryan Biedscheid in Santa Fe ordered Meta to im-

plement measures for users in New Mexico intended to protect youth on Facebook and Instagram. The ruling does not affect other states.

Meta must introduce more stringent age verification, restrict users under 18 to no more than 90 hours a month and shut off push notifications overnight and during school hours. Parents must consent to the number of “likes” on a child’s post being shown, the ruling said.

Meta must also ban sexualized chatbot interactions with minors and blur images suspected of containing nudity.

The judge rejected some of the changes New Mexico requested, including modifica-



New Mexico court directs Meta to strengthen protections for teens on Facebook and Instagram. REUTERS

tions to Meta’s algorithms and features such as infinite scroll and autoplay videos. The company said during the trial that

some changes the state sought were not technologically possible and could force it to exit the state.

What was the basis of the judge’s decision?

Biedscheid ruled that Meta created a public nuisance, agreeing with New Mexico’s claims that Facebook and Instagram were designed in ways that addicted young users and did not adequately protect them from sexual exploitation.

Reuters last year reported on company documents that showed Meta’s AI chatbots could “engage a child in conversations that are romantic or sensual.”

The judge rejected Meta’s call to dismiss the case under Section 230 of the Communications Decency Act, which generally shields online platforms from liability over user content.

What is a public nuisance?

Public nuisance claims traditionally have been used in cases involving threats to public health or safety, such as pollution. More recently, governments have brought them in lawsuits against companies that sold or marketed tobacco and opioids.

In the New Mexico case, the judge found that the harms from Meta’s platforms extended beyond individual users and imposed broader costs on families, schools, hospitals and law enforcement.

Meta argued at trial that it had not violated any public right such as access to air

or water, that its social media platforms are not the only ones used by the state’s young residents and that the case ignored the impact of other apps.

How does this affect other cases?

The New Mexico case does not directly impact thousands of other pending lawsuits by children and families or public nuisance claims by more than 40 states and 1,300 school districts. But New Mexico Attorney General Raúl Torrez has called the decision a “blueprint” for governments seeking to force changes on social media platforms through the courts.

From training at dry pond to World U20 javelin silver

Yadav once trained with a wooden javelin. Two years on, 19-year-old has won India's first medal at the 2026 World U-20 Championships

Nihal Koshie
New Delhi, August 8

WHEN HE took up the sport two years ago, Ashish Yadav trained with a wooden javelin in a dry pond with patches of quicksand near his village, Mawaiya, Mirzapur. It was more out of compulsion than choice, as there were no other open spaces. On Saturday, the 19-year-old, inspired by Olympic Games and World Championship medallist Neeraj Chopra's exploits, won a silver — India's first medal in this edition of the Under-20 World Championships — at Hayward Field in Oregon, USA.

Ashish became the first Indian since Chopra's historic gold in 2016 to win a medal in javelin at the junior World Championships. Though Ashish didn't produce a big throw like Chopra's 86.48 metres — the junior world record, set in Bydgoszcz, Poland — he did what is crucial in championships: secure a podium finish. His throw of 74.09 metres was enough for silver.

South Africa's Jan-Hendrik Heymans won gold (80.50m), while Addison James of Dominica, with 73.89 metres, registered a national record to win bronze.

Ashish didn't get enough time to practise after returning from a knee injury. But his resolve to win a medal helped open India's account despite him not being fully fit.

"There are sportspersons in my family. My aunty, Punam Yadav, is a weightlifter who won a medal at the 2014 Commonwealth Games. Seeing her, I wanted to get into sports. My uncle is a discus thrower and an Army man. Neeraj *bhai* is an inspiration for taking up the javelin. I still have a lot more to do, so I don't want to be compared to Neeraj *bhai*. But this medal is a good start for me because it proved that I can compete at the highest level and finish on the podium. I was about 80 per cent



Ashish Yadav became the first Indian since Neeraj Chopra to win a javelin medal at Jr Worlds. ASIAN ATHLETICS Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGjOKH6oBd0F>

“Until I was 17, I used to help my father, who is a milkman. From the age of 10, I went to houses in and around my village and milked cows and buffaloes. My father would sell the milk.”

Milkman father

Until Ashish became serious about the sport, he helped his father in the milk distribution business.

"Until I was 17, I used to help my father, who is a milkman. From the age of 10, I went to houses in and around my village and milked cows and buffaloes. My father would sell the milk," Ashish said.

His discus-thrower uncle, Dharamraj Singh, irritated that he neither took up a sport seriously nor studied well, gave him a tongue-lashing one day. The uncle promised to get him wooden javelins, which cost Rs 1,200 each. Mawaiya and nearby villages didn't have a proper ground. But that didn't stop Ashish from trying to become the next Chopra.

"The pond, which is about 2 kilometres away from home, would dry up. I could throw without being worried about hitting someone with the wooden javelin. But there was a risk because there were spots which were like quicksand. Every year, there are incidents of children being sucked into the mud. Children have died too. I got a beating a few times when my family got to know about where I was training. But I was always careful. There is a Shivji mandir

near the pond, so I was sure I would be protected. There is no proper ground in Mirzapur or in my village. I had to start somewhere," Ashish said.

ASHISH YADAV,
SILVER MEDALLIST, U20 WORLDS.

Chopra on loop

Dharamraj said Ashish would watch videos of Chopra on loop. "I told Ashish you have to work hard and not lose heart because javelin is not an easy sport. Also, the competition in India is very tough. The silver at the World Championships proves he is on the right track."

Winning silver at the Under-20 World Championships made up for his fifth-place finish at the Under-20 Asian Championships in Hong Kong in May. Ashish got his big break when he was selected to train at the Hisar Centre, which is run by the

Sports Authority of India in collaboration with the *Inspire Institute of Sport*.

"Usually, athletes from Uttar Pradesh don't get selected at the Hisar Centre easily. But Arvind Kumar, the coach at the Hisar Centre, saw potential in me and selected me. When I joined the centre, my weight was just 70 kilograms; now it is 84 kg. I am six feet and one inch tall. Earlier, I was underweight, but my coach taught me the importance of eating well and training right. He is like a god to me; he treats me like his own son. Whatever money I needed for the sport, my uncle and my coach would give. They have not asked me to return a single rupee."

Coach Kumar was impressed by Ashish's explosive speed, though he didn't top the trials with 64 metres. "We conduct motor-ability tests. His standing board jump was 3.10 metres. Anything over 3 metres is very good; most of the kids do about 2.70 metres, 2.80 metres. His vertical jump was also good. He had a lean body, was tall and his speed was good, which can help a javelin thrower," he said.

Before the final, the coach told Ashish not to overthink.

Ashish's next target is to improve his speed on the runway. "Technically, I have to make changes. I won't rest on my laurels. Javelin is booming in India; one can't afford to take it easy."

Decoding Beijing's Black Box

In China's Wars, Vijay Gokhale offers a scholarly analysis of the motivations and impulses behind China's aggressive actions with its adversaries from an Indian perspective

Shubhajt Roy

CHINA'S DECISION-making has been a black box. It is seen to be opaque. So, it poses a unique challenge to neighbours, partners and adversaries alike, who struggle to understand the motivations, impulses and factors that shape and influence Beijing's strategy towards the world.

Vijay Gokhale, who has spent the better part of his diplomatic career dealing with China from three vantage points — Hong Kong, Taiwan and Beijing — has tried to decode Beijing's black box. He began his career as a young diplomat learning Mandarin in Hong Kong (before the British left), and then served in Beijing during the Tiananmen protests, and went back to Beijing as India's ambassador in 2016-17. He served as India's Foreign Secretary till his retirement in 2020. In Delhi, he manned the China desk, as joint secretary in the Ministry of External Affairs.

In his previous book, *The Long Game: How the Chinese Negotiate with India* (2021), he sought to illustrate the various ways and means in which Chinese negotiators interact, influence the agenda, and shape outcomes — sometimes with deception and subterfuge as essential tools. In the book, he had given a toolkit used by Chinese negotiators — and he has had wide experience in dealing with his counterparts in Beijing — that is useful for practising diplomats, business persons and scholars and students of China to understand their behaviour, and negotiating style.

In the latest book, *China's Wars: The Politics and Diplomacy Behind its Military Coercion*, Gokhale takes a step forward: He analyses Chinese motivations and im-

pulses behind their aggressive and kinetic actions with their adversaries.

He uses four case studies: Taiwan Strait Crisis of 1958, India-China war of 1962, Sino-Soviet conflict of 1969 and the China-Vietnam War, and seeks to come up with a framework for Chinese behaviour.

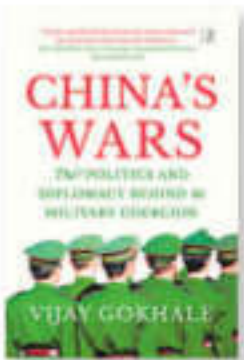
While all these cases have been analysed earlier, he is uniquely positioned to conduct the academic analysis that can be useful for current and future diplomats. He says that this is not a book of war history, but a "history of the geopolitics of war".

With India and China being neighbours, the book has been written to analyse it from the Indian perspective and draw lessons for India in future. At a time when the border-standoff between India and China is still ongoing, Gokhale's book is a timely scholarly analysis.

India has suffered a war with China in 1962 and come close to conflict on other occasions since. China's claim on Indian territory has gradually expanded as has, more recently, its encroachment on the ground. How and when China will deploy force in pursuit of its claims in the future is, therefore, a legitimate question in the minds of Indian strategists and thinkers.

Scholars have argued that China uses conflict as a tool of "psychological deterrence" and the Chinese draw no clear distinction between peacetime and wartime. Gokhale notes that fighting and talking go hand-in-hand with the singular objective of securing China's political goals, which might be territorial, geopolitical or purely related to domestic politics.

Concluding quite candidly that the 1962 war delivered a "psychological-political blow" to India, Gokhale makes a case that the invasion was "not a sudden counter-re-



CHINA'S WARS: THE POLITICS AND DIPLOMACY BEHIND ITS MILITARY COERCION
VIJAY GOKHALE
Simon & Schuster
210 pages
₹699



Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>
BEING NEIGHBOURS
Prime Minister Narendra Modi with Chinese President Xi Jinping

sponse to Indian aggression" and had been "carefully planned." And it sharply "undercuts Indian self-confidence."

In the current scenario of the border standoff, which is most relevant, he says that the era of peaceful coexistence is at an end, and India must therefore prepare for a prolonged period of armed coexistence.

While he assesses that the India of 2025 is not what it was in 1962, "China knows a total victory is not likely."

Gokhale's book argues that China risks potential reputational damage through an open conflict with India and is likely to use more tools of coercion to achieve political goals in future. However, he cautions rightly that there is no circumstance under which large-scale conflict between India and China should be ruled out entirely.

As someone who served in Beijing after Chinese President Xi Jinping assumed office, he makes a case for carefully monitoring internal political developments within the People's Republic of China.

In this context, this line is telling: "It is not uncommon for beleaguered leaders and regimes to deflect public attention from a serious domestic crisis to an external threat but authoritarian regimes such as China are more likely to do so as they

lack legal or popular legitimacy." He cites that the stand-offs in Depsang and Chumar in 2013 and 2014 coincided with the political transition from pre-Xi Jinping era to the Xi era.

In India's case, China adopts what he calls a "fight and talk" strategy, where "grey-zone coercion" (military intimidation, including massing of troops on the border, large-scale land, sea or air exercises or threats of force, employment of paramilitary for law enforcement, manipulation of borders through cartographic aggression) and "negotiations" go hand-in-hand to achieve a favourable outcome. He wisely notes that the "grey-zone warfare" is likely to be adopted against India more frequently in the future.

The book eruditely explains Beijing's strategy but as someone who is deeply aware of the recent crises in Depsang, Demchok, Doklam and Galwan, the book could have been richer if he would have added more insights and granular details from these episodes. Nevertheless, it is an outstanding work for students of Chinese strategy at a time when China's comprehensive national strength and global role has become key to geopolitics and geo-economics.